

# Djokovic Battles Back to Beat Zverev at the China Open

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Novak Djokovic came back from a set down to beat **top seed** Alexander Zverev. He reached the **semi-finals** of the China Open. Djokovic, a 39-year-old from Serbia, won 4-6 6-4 6-4. Zverev is ranked number two in the world.

It was the first time they had played in just under 16 months. Zverev, who is 29, won the first set. Then Djokovic fought back. He broke Zverev's **serve** at 5-4 in the second set to **level the match**. In the third set, he broke Zverev again at 5-4 to win. The loss hurt Zverev's hopes of finishing the year as the world's number one player.

"These are the kind of moments that I still play for, compete for," Djokovic said. The win extended his unbeaten run in Beijing to 32 matches. He is one step closer to a seventh China Open **title** and his first trophy of 2026. He has won 24 **Grand Slam titles**, but this year has been hard. "It's been a struggle this year for different reasons," he said.

Next, he plays Daniil Medvedev on Monday.

## Word Treasure

**semi-finals** -- The round with four players left, before the final.

**top seed** -- The player ranked highest going into a tournament.

**serve** -- The shot that starts each point in tennis.

**level the match** -- Make the score of sets equal again.

**Grand Slam** -- One of the four biggest tennis tournaments.

**title** -- A championship win.

## Break it down

**Opening:** Djokovic beats Zverev to reach the semi-finals

Ages, score and the first meeting in 16 months

How Djokovic came back in the second and third sets

What the win means and his comments

The next match

## Why it matters

Tennis fans can see how an experienced champion can fight back from behind against one of the best players in the world.

## Test what you remember

### 1. Who did Djokovic beat?

- ☐ (A) Daniil Medvedev
- ☐ (B) Francisco Cerundolo
- ☐ (C) Alexander Zverev
- ☐ (D) Hubert Hurkacz

### 2. What was the score of the match?

- ☐ (A) 6-0 6-0
- ☐ (B) 4-6 6-4 6-4
- ☐ (C) 4-6 4-6
- ☐ (D) 7-6 6-3

### 3. How old is Djokovic?

- ☐ (A) 29
- ☐ (B) 32
- ☐ (C) 24
- ☐ (D) 39

### 4. How long was it since they last played?

- ☐ (A) Just under 16 months
- ☐ (B) Almost five years
- ☐ (C) One week
- ☐ (D) Three days

### 5. How many Grand Slam titles has Djokovic won?

- ☐ (A) 7
- ☐ (B) 39
- ☐ (C) 32
- ☐ (D) 24

### 6. Who does Djokovic play next?

- ☐ (A) Hubert Hurkacz
- ☐ (B) Daniil Medvedev
- ☐ (C) Carlos Alcaraz
- ☐ (D) Alexander Zverev

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: D 4: A 5: D 6: B

## Questions to think about

**MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):**